ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Present perfect: simple or continuous

Choose between result, quantity and completion on one hand, and duration, repetition or temporary process on the other. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use present perfect: simple or continuous to frame a past-to-present situation according to whether result or activity is more important while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Choose between result, quantity and completion on one hand, and duration, repetition or temporary process on the other.

MODEL

We have reviewed twelve files, and we have been checking the final one all morning.

have + participle | have been + verb-ing

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main present perfect: simple or continuous patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses frame a past-to-present situation according to whether result or activity is more important.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in updates, interviews, work reviews and everyday explanations.

Build meaning before form

Choose between result, quantity and completion on one hand, and duration, repetition or temporary process on the other.

What present perfect: simple or continuous communicates

Choose between result, quantity and completion on one hand, and duration, repetition or temporary process on the other.

The central purpose is to frame a past-to-present situation according to whether result or activity is more important. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

We have reviewed twelve files.	a present result or completed quantity
We have been checking the final file all morning.	the duration of an activity continuing into the present
You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.	a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: have + participle | have been + verb-ing. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “We have reviewed twelve files, and we have been checking the final one all morning.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Completed result	have + past participle	We have reviewed twelve files.
Ongoing duration	have been + -ing + for/since	We have been checking the final file all morning.
Recent evidence	have been + -ing	You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a present result or completed quantity	Completed result
the duration of an activity continuing into the present	Ongoing duration
a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present	Recent evidence

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in updates, interviews, work reviews and everyday explanations. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
have	participle	have been	verb-ing

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: frame a past-to-present situation according to whether result or activity is more important.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits updates, interviews, work reviews and everyday explanations.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Completed result	have + past participle	We have reviewed twelve files.
Ongoing duration	have been + -ing + for/since	We have been checking the final file all morning.
Recent evidence	have been + -ing	You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

We have reviewed twelve files.	a present result or completed quantity
We have been checking the final file all morning.	the duration of an activity continuing into the present
You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.	a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use the continuous when a finished quantity is the focus.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use since with a duration or for with a starting point.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Avoid the continuous with stative verbs unless the meaning becomes active.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a present result or completed quantity?

OPTIONS We have reviewed twelve files. · We have been checking the final file all morning. · You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the duration of an activity continuing into the present?

OPTIONS We have been checking the final file all morning. · You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy. · We have reviewed twelve files.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present?

OPTIONS You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy. · We have reviewed twelve files. · We have been checking the final file all morning.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “We have reviewed twelve files.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a present result or completed quantity · the duration of an activity continuing into the present · a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “We have been checking the final file all morning.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the duration of an activity continuing into the present · a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present · a present result or completed quantity

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present · a present result or completed quantity · the duration of an activity continuing into the present

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“We have reviewed twelve files.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Completed result / Ongoing duration / Recent evidence · Gap 2: a present result or completed quantity / the duration of an activity continuing into the present / a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“We have been checking the final file all morning.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Ongoing duration / Recent evidence / Completed result · Gap 2: the duration of an activity continuing into the present / a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present / a present result or completed quantity

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Recent evidence / Completed result / Ongoing duration · Gap 2: a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present / a present result or completed quantity / the duration of an activity continuing into the present

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a present result or completed quantity: _____. Choose the model that expresses the duration of an activity continuing into the present: _____. Choose the model that expresses a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present: _____. Choose the model built with have + past participle: _____. Choose the model built with have been + -ing + for/since: _____. Choose the model built with have been + -ing: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

We have been checking the final file all morning. · We have reviewed twelve files. · You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

We _____ twelve files. We _____ the final file all morning. You _____ in the garden; your shoes are muddy. State the full structural pattern for Completed result: _____. State the full structural pattern for Ongoing duration: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Twelve files are now complete.” using the Completed result pattern to express a present result or completed quantity.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The checking began earlier and is still relevant now.” using the Ongoing duration pattern to express the duration of an activity continuing into the present.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The muddy shoes are evidence of recent gardening.” using the Recent evidence pattern to express a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Twelve files are now complete.” using the Completed result pattern to express a present result or completed quantity.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Completed result to express a present result or completed quantity, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Ongoing duration to express the duration of an activity continuing into the present, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Recent evidence to express a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

We have reviewed twelve files.

Completed result is the best match because a present result or completed quantity.

A2

We have been checking the final file all morning.

Ongoing duration is the best match because the duration of an activity continuing into the present.

A3

You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

Recent evidence is the best match because a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present.

A4

a present result or completed quantity

The Completed result pattern communicates a present result or completed quantity.

A5

the duration of an activity continuing into the present

The Ongoing duration pattern communicates the duration of an activity continuing into the present.

A6

a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present

The Recent evidence pattern communicates a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Completed result / a present result or completed quantity

The structure belongs to the Completed result pattern. Its communicative purpose is a present result or completed quantity.

B2

Ongoing duration / the duration of an activity continuing into the present

The structure belongs to the Ongoing duration pattern. Its communicative purpose is the duration of an activity continuing into the present.

B3

Recent evidence / a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present

The structure belongs to the Recent evidence pattern. Its communicative purpose is a recent repeated or temporary activity visible in the present.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

We have reviewed twelve files.

Completed result: have + past participle.

C2

We have been checking the final file all morning.

Ongoing duration: have been + -ing + for/since.

C3

You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

Recent evidence: have been + -ing.

C4

We have reviewed twelve files.

Completed result: have + past participle.

C5

We have been checking the final file all morning.

Ongoing duration: have been + -ing + for/since.

C6

You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

Recent evidence: have been + -ing.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

have reviewed

Completed result requires “have reviewed” in this model. have + past participle.

D2

have been checking

Ongoing duration requires “have been checking” in this model. have been + -ing + for/since.

D3

have been working

Recent evidence requires “have been working” in this model. have been + -ing.

D4

have + past participle

Completed result is built as have + past participle.

D5

have been + -ing + for/since

Ongoing duration is built as have been + -ing + for/since.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

We have reviewed twelve files.

have + past participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended completed result effect.

E2

We have been checking the final file all morning.

have been + -ing + for/since. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended ongoing duration effect.

E3

You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy.

have been + -ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended recent evidence effect.

E4

We have reviewed twelve files.

have + past participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended completed result effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

We have reviewed twelve files. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses have + past participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

We have been checking the final file all morning. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses have been + -ing + for/since accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

You have been working in the garden; your shoes are muddy. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses have been + -ing accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____